resistance. The Basmachi were roaming bands of Muslim men who opposed the presence of Russians in Central Asia.[163] After the invasions of Khiva and Bokhara, the ranks of the Basmachi swelled and were joined by the emir of Bokhara and a couple of prominent Jadids, all of which raised the standing of the movement among the local population.[164] By 1921 then, the rebellion had become a refuge for all those who were opposed to Soviet Russia's presence in Central Asia, thereby proving a constant source of irritation and embarrassment to the Bolshevik government who were trying so hard to maintain a pro-Islam image. Indeed, the Basmachi resistance and the invasions of Bokhara and Khiva demonstrate just how problematic Moscow's foreign policy could be. Even after the Second Comintern Congress had apparently solved the theoretical issues about collaboration with nationalists and pan-Islamists (and tempered some of the initial extremism displayed by local activists), this did not remedy the practical problems the Bolsheviks faced in trying to extend their influence into Central and South Asia. For, try as the Bolsheviks might to temper their ideology and pander to nationalist sentiment, many Asian Muslims were not to be fooled; ultimately the Russian Soviet government was a foreign Communist power whose belief system was fundamentally incompatible with Islam. Furthermore, Moscow's dual policy of conducting diplomatic relations with Afghanistan while simultaneously deposing neighbouring native rulers was a risky one, as it threatened to alienate emir Amanullah and push him towards the British.

As it was, Amanullah faced a dilemma. As the new British ambassador in Kabul, Colonel Humphrys, explained, the emir could not afford to alienate Soviet Russia by becoming too involved in the affairs of the likes of Bokhara, yet he also could not outright abandon this region for fear of being regarded as a traitor to Islam. The idea of being the saviour of those Muslims who rejected Soviet rule was also a tempting proposition. In Humphry's opinion, Amanullah had in fact become obsessed with the issue of Bokhara.[165] The presence of emir Alim, who had fled to Afghanistan in 1921, was also a constant reminder of the plight of that country. How far this obsession was truly motivated by religious affinity, however, is questionable. The Indian government certainly believed that it was Afghan ambitions for northern expansion (since southern expansion was largely out of the question) which really inspired this interest in Turkestan. Despite